

Introduction

Continuing from medieval times, Renaissance magic was often divided into high and low forms. High magic included scholarly experiments with alchemy (turning base metals into gold), while low magic encompassed popular folk traditions, such as local “cunning folk” providing spells to ward off warts.

Practices were also divided into beneficial and harmful magic. European attitudes were often simplistic and arbitrary when deciding what was evil. At a time of much colonial expansion, Christian European colonizers frequently misconstrued indigenous non-European traditions as evil, heretical sorcery. In Mexico, for example, traditional Aztec occultism intertwined good and bad aspects—subtleties often misunderstood by the Spanish colonizers who crushed the Aztec Empire in 1521.

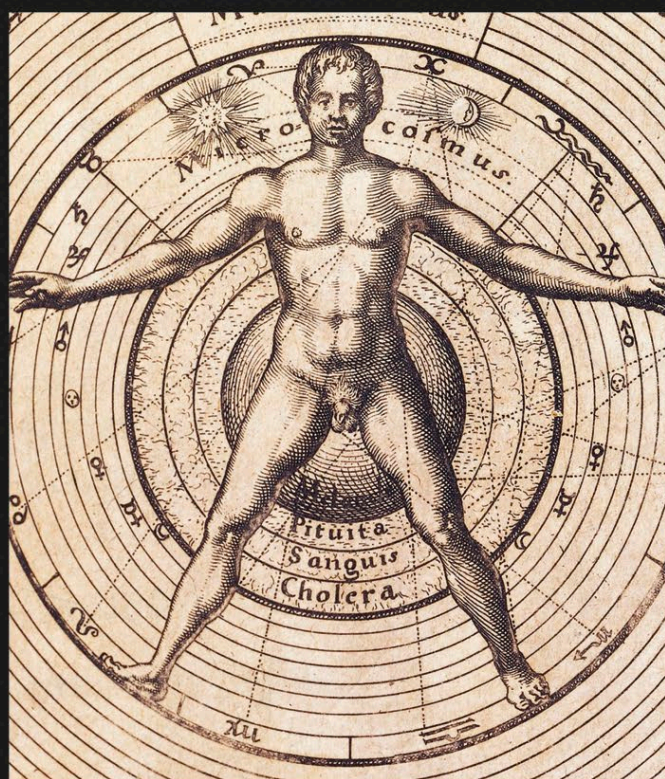
This was the period when the stereotyped persona of the evil female witch, so familiar today, became firmly fixed. The 1500s and 1600s witnessed by far

the most intense era of anti-witchcraft legislation, persecutions, and prosecutions—from the 1640s witch hunts of self-styled British Witch-Finder General Matthew Hopkins and the Archbishop of Trier’s German persecutions to the infamous trials of 1692–1693 in Salem, Massachusetts. Across Europe, thousands were executed for supposed witchcraft—men as well as women—although the Spanish Inquisition (the judicial body set up to stamp out heresy), at its peak at this time, was skeptical about witches and focussed instead on religious persecution of those straying from its rigid Catholic ideology.

The Renaissance stimulated intellectual inquiry in Europe that interwove different areas of knowledge, questioning humans’ place in the universe, their relationship to God, and how the natural world worked. Ideas that would now be categorized as magical or occult then simply joined this complex brew. Magical strands were woven into important



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Human life and the universe see p.135



Kabbalah tree of life see p.136–37